

However, towards the late 1950s, neither the US nor Europe were making ground-breaking strides in rail transport. That honour went to Japan.



▲ **During its time**, the English Electric prototype *Deltic*, first tested in 1955, was the most powerful diesel locomotive in the world.

Staying modern

On 1 October 1964, as the two inaugural Hikari Super Express Shinkansen, or bullet trains as they popularly came to be called, pulled into Tokyo and Osaka in Japan, they revolutionized the way the world looked at speed and train travel. Japan's innovation came on the heels of the French Le Capitole, which was introduced in 1960 and became the world's first 200 km/h passenger service. Railways tried to keep up by focusing on modernizing their services from using diesel and electric locomotives and focussing on comfort to bidding farewell to steam.

However, it seemed like the railways were fighting a difficult battle. Car sales were increasing and airplane travel was fast becoming the preferred means of transport. The 1963 Beeching Report in Britain's recommendation involved closing 30 per cent of the railway network. The US took drastic measures consolidating 20 passenger railway lines under Amtrak, which began services in 1971 and focussed on making long distance train travel profitable.

Faster and faster